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AB 1626 Wins Final Passage and Heads to the Governor's Desk

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Last week, the California State Legislature passed AB 1626, key legislation that will put mental health and substance use disorder training in the hands of youth sports coaches. Authored by Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel, Blanca Pacheco and Jacqui Irwin, AB 1626 passed with overwhelming bipartisan support and now heads to Gov. Gavin Newsom's desk.

For coaches across California, AB 1626 turns good intentions into real preparation. It requires K-12 sports coaches to complete training on recognizing the warning signs of depression, anxiety, eating disorders, substance use disorders and suicidal ideation – and how to connect a struggling student-athlete to resources. It also directs the California Department of Education to build a model training that recreational and club coaches statewide can use to do the same.

"For many young people, mental health intervention can be the difference between life and death," said Gabriel. "Coaches are uniquely positioned and are often the first to notice when young people are struggling and in need of help. This bill will empower youth sports coaches with the tools and training they need to help students in crisis."

"I'm grateful for all the coaches who have helped me build confidence and resilience, on and off the court," said Stephen Curry, an NBA champion. "Every kid deserves that kind of coach, and we've been proud to make investments to ensure coaches in Oakland have the tools to be a great leader. Policies like Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel's bill help create a strong foundation for coaching practices that can make a lasting impact in an athlete's life."

A Crisis Playing Out on California's Fields and Courts

Studies show that teenagers across the state are struggling with mental health issues at an increasing rate. California's young men and boys have experienced an alarming rise in suicide rates and feel more disconnected from school, work and relationships. Meanwhile, young female athletes face their own elevated risks of depression, anxiety, body image struggles and eating disorders.

Coaches often see young athletes for numerous hours each week and can be the first to notice when something is wrong. Yet only one in five coaches report feeling highly confident in their ability to support a student dealing with a mental health or substance use disorder, and four in five say they feel less than fully prepared.

The goal is to ensure the adults who kids already trust are ready to help when it matters most.

Backed by Champions On and Off the Field

AB 1626 is sponsored by the California Alliance of Children and Family Services (CA Alliance), Mental Health America of California, the Play Equity Fund and the California Commission on the Status of Women and Girls. It is backed by State Superintendent of Public Instruction Tony Thurmond, the San Francisco Giants, U.S. Soccer Foundation, San Francisco 49ers, NAMI California, the American Academy of Pediatrics of California, the Association of California School Administrators, and dozens of education, youth and mental health organizations.

"This bill is about turning awareness into life-saving action," said Irwin. "The community I represent in Ventura County lost a remarkable person when the life of Sarah Shulze was tragically cut short by suicide in 2022. Sarah was a talented multi-event runner, and her loss underscores the urgent need to better equip the adults our students trust to recognize and respond to mental health warning signs."

"Everyone talks about prevention, but few invest in it. AB 1626 is what prevention looks like in practice," said Pete Weldy, CEO of CA Alliance. "Youth mental health has reached a crisis point, but early identification can change the trajectory of a young person's life. When a trusted adult, like a high school coach, is trained to recognize when a young athlete is struggling … that coach can connect that young athlete with care and, in some cases, save their life."

What's Next

After AB 1626 lands on the governor's desk, he will have until Sept. 30 to decide whether to veto the bill or sign it into law.

The post AB 1626 Wins Final Passage and Heads to the Governor's Desk appeared first on The San Fernando Valley Sun.

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